

Feminist media theory

First-Wave Feminism

- emerging in the late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries
- primarily concerned with legal, political, and civil rights, particularly women's access to education, property, and suffrage.
- Media and popular culture were not its central focus, but culture was understood as a site of moral and ideological regulation that reinforced women's exclusion from public life.
- Literary culture, print media, and dominant representations of femininity often positioned women as passive, self-sacrificing, and morally pure.
- Feminist interventions sought to challenge patriarchal representations that confined women to domesticity and silence. Writing itself was political: women's entry into authorship disrupted dominant cultural norms.
- Cultural critique here focused less on mass media and more on challenging the symbolic ideals of femininity that underpinned legal and social inequality.

Second-Wave Feminism

- 1960s and 1970s placed media, culture, and popular representation at the centre of feminist critique.
- The slogan "the personal is political" extended feminist analysis into everyday life, including advertising, film, television, literature, and popular music.
- Feminists argued that media reproduced patriarchy by normalising women's subordination, sexual objectification, and confinement to domestic and reproductive roles.
- Cultural texts were read as ideological mechanisms that shaped gendered subjectivity. Influential work analysed how femininity was constructed through representation and how women learned to see themselves through male-defined norms.
- Media were therefore understood as powerful technologies of socialisation, producing gender difference.

Postmodern and Psychoanalytic Feminism

- mid-1970s onwards, feminist media theory became more theoretically sophisticated, drawing on psychoanalysis, semiotics, and post-structuralism.
- Work on cinema argued that popular culture is structured by visual pleasure organised around a male gaze, in which women function as objects of desire rather than active subjects.
- Media pleasure itself became politically suspect, seen as bound up with patriarchal power and unconscious fantasy.
- At the same time, debates emerged over whether women could take pleasure in popular culture without simply reproducing their own oppression.

Third-Wave Feminism

- challenged earlier feminist tendencies to treat women as a single, unified group.
- Media and popular culture were re-evaluated as ambivalent spaces that could reproduce sexism while also enabling resistance, play, and self-expression. Attention shifted to difference, intersectionality,.

Cyberfeminism and Fourth-Wave Feminism

- foreground digital media, online culture, and networked communication.
- New media technologies are understood as reshaping embodiment, identity, and power.
- Cyberspace is theorised as a potential site for disrupting gender binaries, biological essentialism, and patriarchal authority, though also as a space of intensified surveillance and control.
- Contemporary feminism analyses social media, influencer culture, and digital activism as arenas where visibility, self-branding, and affect are central.
- Media are no longer just representational systems but infrastructures through which power, pleasure, and governance operate.